

Screening & Brief Intervention (SBIRT)

Learner guide | SWP-007 | School of Substance Use & Addiction Recovery

This guide supports a three-part learning sequence for Screening & Brief Intervention (SBIRT). By the end of the course, you should be able to use screening and brief-intervention principles to identify and respond to risky substance use.

Practice notice: Apply the law, organisational policy, supervision requirements, and approved referral pathways that govern your setting. This material supports learning and does not replace urgent safeguarding, clinical, or legal procedures.

Learning objectives

- Use screening and brief-intervention principles to identify and respond to risky substance use.
- Apply the key ideas from Substance-use continuum.
- Apply the key ideas from Screening and feedback.
- Apply the key ideas from Brief intervention and referral.

Course structure

Module	Focus	Suggested study time
1. Substance-use continuum	stigma-free language, risk factors, protective factors, and screening purpose	10 to 15 minutes
2. Screening and feedback	validated-tool principles, consent, interpretation, and brief feedback	10 to 15 minutes
3. Brief intervention and referral	motivational conversation, harm reduction, referral matching, and documentation	10 to 15 minutes

Module 1 Substance-use continuum

This module focuses on stigma-free language, risk factors, protective factors, and screening purpose. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Stigma-free language
- Risk factors
- Protective factors
- Screening purpose

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of substance-use continuum in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of stigma-free language, risk factors, protective factors, and screening purpose. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through substance-use continuum safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 2 Screening and feedback

This module focuses on validated-tool principles, consent, interpretation, and brief feedback. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Validated-tool principles
- Consent
- Interpretation
- Brief feedback

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of screening and feedback in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of validated-tool principles, consent, interpretation, and brief feedback. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through screening and feedback safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Module 3 Brief intervention and referral

This module focuses on motivational conversation, harm reduction, referral matching, and documentation. Work through the material with a current practice setting in mind, but remove identifying information from any examples you record.

What to pay attention to

- Motivational conversation
- Harm reduction
- Referral matching
- Documentation

Learning sequence

Start by defining the purpose of brief intervention and referral in relation to the course outcome. Notice where professional judgement is needed and where a local procedure must guide the next step.

Examine the practical implications of motivational conversation, harm reduction, referral matching, and documentation. Separate observations from assumptions, identify strengths as well as concerns, and be clear about information that must be checked with a person, family, colleague, or approved source.

Use a respectful, collaborative approach. Explain your role, seek informed participation where appropriate, and document only information that is relevant, accurate, and necessary for the purpose of the work.

When a concern exceeds your role, supervision, competence, or authority, pause and use the correct escalation route. A prompt referral and a clear handover can protect continuity of support.

Practice reflection

Choose a de-identified practice situation. What information would help you work through brief intervention and referral safely, and what would require consultation or a local policy check?

Course activity

Use the accompanying worksheet to apply the course sequence to a short case. Your completed activity should show what you noticed, the action you would take within your role, and what you would escalate or verify locally.

Assessment preparation

- Review the distinction between: SBIRT sequence.
- Review the distinction between: interpretation.
- Review the distinction between: harm reduction.
- Review the distinction between: referral.

References and local adaptation

- SWEEP Academy Course Content Outlines, production blueprint for this course.
- The current legislation, professional standards, safeguarding procedures, and referral directories for the delivery jurisdiction.
- The learner's employer or placement policy, supervision arrangements, and documentation standards.